A Tribute to Emmett Till

By Marilyn Nelson and Dominique Christina

A Wreath for Emmett Till by Marilyn Nelson

III

Pierced by the screams of a shortened childhood,
my heartwood has been scarred for fifty years
by what I heard, with hundreds of green ears.
That jackal laughter. Two hundred years I stood
listening to small struggles to find food,
to the songs of creature life, which disappears
and comes again, to the music of the spheres.
Two hundred years of deaths I understood.
Then slaughter axed one quiet summer night,
shivering the deep silence of the stars.
A running boy, five men in close pursuit.
One dark, five pale faces in the moonlight.
Noise, silence, back-slaps. One match, five cigars.
Emmett Till's name still catches in the throat.

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INTRODUCTION

The brutal abduction and murder of 14-year-old Emmett Till on August 28, 1955, galvanized the emerging Civil Rights Movement. Till was visiting relatives in Mississippi when the fourteen-year-old was accused of whistling at Carolyn Bryant, a white woman who was a cashier at a grocery store.

Four days later, Bryant's husband and his half-brother kidnapped Till, beat the teenager brutally, dragged him to the bank of the Tallahatchie River, shot him in the head, tied him with barbed wire to a large metal fan and shoved his mutilated body into the water. The men were tried for murder, but an all-white, male jury acquitted them.

A Wreath for Emmett Till by Marilyn Nelson and Strange Fruit by Dominique Christina

IV

Emmett Till's name still catches in my throat,
like syllables waylaid in a stutterer's mouth.
A fourteen-year-old stutterer, in the South
to visit relatives and to be taught
the family's ways. His mother had finally bought
that White Sox cap; she'd made him swear an oath
to be careful around white folks. She's told him the
truth
of many a Mississippi anecdote:

Some white folks have blind souls. In his suitcase
she'd packed dungarees, T-shirts, underwear,
and comic books. She'd given him a note
for the conductor, waved to his chubby face,
wondered if he'd remember to brush his hair.
Her only child. A body left to bloat.

V

Your only child, a body thrown to bloat,
mother of sorrows, of justice denied.
Surely you must have thought of suicide,
seeing his gray flesh, chains around his throat.
Surely you didn't know you would devote
the rest of your changed life to dignified
public remembrance of how Emmett died,
innocence slaughtered by the hands of hate.
If sudden loving light proclaimed you blest
would you bow your head in humility,
your healed heart overflow with gratitude?
Would you say yes, like the mother of Christ?

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Or would you say no to your destiny,
mother of a boy martyr, if you could?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marilyn Nelson
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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

**NOTE: The complete text of A Wreath for Emmett Till consists of 15 sonnets – this compilation uses only an excerpt of 3 of the 15.*

TRANSITION

In an interview, Dominique Christina explained . . . "Poetry is storytelling. Stories are medicine. They've always been. Stories are so critical. I tell you the story of Emmett Till as a way for you to locate your own humanness, find yourself inside it somewhere. We know each other and stories facilitate that better than anything else." Strange Fruit by Dominique Christina

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Strange Fruit (*For Emmett Till*)
by Dominique Christina

"Southern trees bear a strange fruit.
Blood on the leaves and blood at the root."

In this photo he's laughing and
there's no cotton gin tied 'round his waist.
He's not stretched into swollen limbs.
His eyes are still hazel and
recognizable, two neat white rows of perfect teeth
sit totem-like in his mouth and
the world didn't know him because
he'd not been murdered yet.

He's still slipping into the kitchen to
get another piece of cornbread
while his mama ain't lookin'.
He'll mash it with his fingers,
drink some buttermilk and laugh
with his eyes and they're still hazel
and bright like stars in uppercase and
ain't nobody gouged 'em out
or shut 'em closed and when he goes

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to school he'll do a silly dance with his
arms and legs cocked out in odd angles and
his classmates will laugh and there'll
be no cotton gin tied 'round his waist.

"Pastoral scenes of the gallant south,
the bulging eyes and the twisted mouths..."

In this photo he's proud of the hat on his head.
You can see that by how straight his neck is
and his mama's in the picture and they got the same
face and his head's high and perfect and
ain't no bullet in it and it'll be months before there is
one
and in those months he's his mother's child,
the smug and overfed man-child all southern
women love to cook for and dote on cuz he
licks the plate clean even if it's leftovers.
He just eats and yes ma'ams and makes you giggle
so much you got to shoo him out the kitchen
just so you can get the pots clean and
he's breathing and whole and
ain't no men dressed like midnight with

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yellow teeth and sunless un-laughing eyes
snatching him out the door
changing everything when neither of 'em
asked to be anything other than
laughing in the kitchen with
the greens still simmering in the pot.

"Here is a fruit for the crows to pluck..."

This last photo's a holocaust.
The one history concretized into
the nighttime musings of black children
who hopscotched above and below the bible belt,
who saw a tattered other worldly version of
the 14 year-old Emmett,
his head poised strangely above a sharp black suit on
the cover of Jet magazine.
There were no eyes, smiling
mischievous man-child wonderful,
cornbread and buttermilk slicking,
fast talking, looking like his mama,
bubblegum pop saunter and sizzle

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straight necked full of tomorrow's boy
staring back into the camera.

What was there, wasn't there at all.
What was there, swallowed the world.
My mama was eight years old when
they painted Emmett Till's fractured image
on the cover of a negro magazine.
Eight years old.
Pigtails, knee socks, pinafores, pleats, and
a heap of pretty girl possibilities.

But I know my grandmother set that book down
with intention on the coffee table
knowing her baby girl would see it and know
what shouldn't be known but what must be known.

This is what the south did when an adolescent mistake
when a fast-talking, finger-snapping negro from up north
whistles and boasts about big city white girl honeys
with rosy lips and no Jim Crow.

It's an imagine I shoved
at my 13 year old son,

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frenetic in my attempt to tell him
that this is black history.
I need him to known that if he isn't
careful, not brave, not the sum total of all
our unlit courage, if he relegates
these stories to cliff-notes,
he'll bleed out and die in the epilogue.

I need you to know, Salih,
that my arms will never be wide enough
to cover sins like these,
that your head held so high
is still a cautionary tale
but to go on and do it anyway and
laugh and dance with your
arms and legs cocked out in odd angles and
slip by me and get the extra cornbread
whenever you can and
be grateful that when you and your boys
say something slick
about the pretty blonde girl
in the front row of algebra...

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You're permitted that levity
after 400 years of
midnights. Necks decorated in nooses.
Plantations that decorated terrorism in
white pillars and mint juleps.
I tell my son to remember Emmett Till,
to remember when his eyes
were still hazel, still smiling
and how high he held his head
to celebrate that brand new hat,
to remember that his mother loved him
and almost couldn't recognize him
after that last whistle left his throat.

I tell him I'll be his mother
and celebrate his brown boy buoyancy
all the days of my life, and that while I don't
know what tomorrow holds,
I know that he'll never be strange fruit,
will never be broken open, will never be strung up,
will never be hog tied,

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will never have his face so like my own
crushed or mangled or hatcheted.

I tell my son:

I'm growing these limbs to get
'round him and surround him and
we'll be strong and
unapologetically black for as long

as we can be.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dominique Christina
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